Philemon 20–25 — Leader / Learner Guide

A Compelling Appendix · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

The Epistle to Philemon · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: Paul closes with a personal word, a public word, and a parting word — confidence that Philemon will do even more than he asks, greetings from fellow workers (including Mark, whose failure was neither fatal nor final), and grace.

"Parting is such sweet sorrow." Paul says goodbye to Philemon and expects to see him — and Onesimus — together.

- **A Personal Word (vv. 20–22):** provide me relief; prove me right; prepare me a room.
- **A Public Word (vv. 23–24):** Epaphras in prison; Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke in partnership.
- **A Parting Word (v. 25):** the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ — saving, sharing, serving.

② Neither Fatal nor Final — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 21	*"knowing that you will do even more than I say"*	Superlative obedience — the second mile (Matt. 5:39–41). Confidence lays things out the right way.
v. 24	*"Mark … my fellow laborer"*	The rest of the story: courageous before (Mark 14:51–52), useful after (Col. 4:10; 2 Tim. 4:11).
v. 25	*"The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit"*	The most important blessing: sharing grace (2 Cor. 8) and serving grace (Heb. 12:28).

"I" and "you" (v. 20): emphatic — until now Philemon profited from Paul; now Paul wants to profit from him in the Lord.
The guest room (v. 22): people don't always do what you expect; they do what you inspect.

③ Teaching Flow

1. **Introduction.** "Parting is such sweet sorrow" — a goodbye Paul says in three words.
2. **A Personal Word (vv. 20–22).** Rejoice and refresh me; simple and superlative obedience; plan and pray for my coming.
3. **A Public Word (v. 23).** Epaphras — one of the Colossians, a man of prayer, Paul's fellow prisoner.
4. **A Public Word (v. 24).** Mark (the rest of the story), Aristarchus, Demas, Luke.
5. **A Parting Word (v. 25).** Grace — sharing grace, serving grace — with your spirit. See you here, there, or in the air.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **Mark 14:51–52, not 15:51:** the sermon as preached gives chapter 15; the young man is in Mark 14:51–52. That he was Mark is an interpretation.
- **1 Peter 5:13:** "Mark my son" is v. 13 (the sermon said v. 14).
- **2 Timothy 4:11:** the text reads "Only Luke is with me"; "stood with me" is the sermon's wording.
- **Hebrews 12:28:** "hold fast to grace" is the preacher's own rendering; NKJV reads "let us have grace."

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Who has put confidence in you that you need to prove right this week?
2. What failure in your past have you treated as fatal or final?
3. Is your giving and serving a chore — or a grace?

Close: This study closes the series: a cautious approach (vv. 1–7), a comprehensive appeal (vv. 8–19), and a compelling appendix (vv. 20–25). Parting is such sweet sorrow — but one day, no more parting.

Full study: A Compelling Appendix — Philemon 20–25 · Source: The Gospel Vault